

Functioning of Statistical Departments

Government of India & Government of Kerala

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Overview of India's Statistical System

- **Federal Structure:** India's statistical system operates on a decentralized federal structure, with distinct roles for the central and state governments.
- **Central Nodal Agency:** The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) acts as the apex body at the national level.
- **State Nodal Agency:** Each state has a State Statistical Bureau (SSB). In Kerala, this is the Department of Economics and Statistics (DES).
- **Objective:** To ensure the availability of reliable, timely, and credible statistics for evidence-based policymaking, economic planning, and governance.

- **Establishment:** Created in 1999 to oversee official statistics and monitor government programs.
- **Structure:** Divided into two main functional wings:
 - *Statistics Wing:* Comprising the National Statistical Office (NSO).
 - *Programme Implementation Wing:* Monitors central sector infrastructure projects.
- **Mandate:** Sets statistical standards, coordinates statistical work across ministries, and maintains liaisons with international bodies like the UNSD, IMF, and World Bank.

- The NSO is the central repository of statistical data in India.
- **Core Divisions:**
 - *Central Statistics Office (CSO)*: Responsible for macroeconomic aggregates and national accounting.
 - *National Sample Survey Office (NSSO)*: Conducts large-scale socio-economic surveys across the country.
- **Data Governance:** Works towards improving data quality, transparency, and integrating new digital data sources for better economic assessment.

Key Functions & Outputs (MoSPI/NSO)

- **National Accounts:** Preparation of Gross Domestic Product (GDP), Gross Value Added (GVA), and capital formation estimates.
- **Industrial Statistics:** Compilation and release of the monthly Index of Industrial Production (IIP) and the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI).
- **Price Statistics:** Releases the Consumer Price Index (CPI), which is crucial for measuring inflation and guiding national monetary policy.
- **Socio-Economic Surveys:** Executes the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) for employment data and the Household Consumption Expenditure Survey (HCES) for poverty estimation.

Government of Kerala: DES Overview

- **Nodal Agency:** The Department of Economics and Statistics (DES) functions under the Planning and Economic Affairs Department.
- **Role:** Serves as the primary agency for the collection, compilation, and analysis of statistics relating to all sectors of the Kerala economy.
- **Structure:** Operates through a central directorate in Thiruvananthapuram with extensive district-level and taluk-level survey units.
- **Alignment:** Works in strict coordination with the State Planning Board and local self-government institutions.

Key Functions of Kerala DES

- **State Income Estimation:** Calculates Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) and per capita income specifically for Kerala.
- **Agricultural Statistics:** Conducts the Establishment of an Agency for Reporting Agricultural Statistics (EARAS) to estimate crop area, production, and yield.
- **Vital Statistics:** Compilation of critical data on births, deaths, and demographic trends essential for Kerala's health planning.
- **Local Level Planning:** Provides localized data sets and decentralized planning statistics directly to Gram Panchayats and Municipalities.

Major Publications & Outputs (Kerala DES)

- **Price Statistics:** Collects and publishes daily, weekly, and monthly prices of essential commodities, which drives the state's cost of living index.
- **Industrial Data:** Assists in state-level compilations for the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI) and computes the state-specific IIP.
- **Economic Review:** Contributes extensive primary data for the Kerala State Planning Board's annual "Economic Review" document.
- **Sample Surveys:** Participates actively in NSSO surveys with matching state samples to ensure highly accurate, district-level representation.

- **Methodological Synchronization:** MoSPI provides the overarching methodological framework, while the Kerala DES executes state-specific data gathering.
- **Matching Samples:** In NSSO surveys, Kerala DES canvasses a matching "state sample" alongside the GoI's "central sample" to generate robust sub-regional estimates.
- **Capacity Building:** MoSPI offers training and standardizes concepts and definitions to ensure data interoperability across the nation.
- **SDG Monitoring:** Both agencies collaborate closely to monitor India's progress on the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) at both national and sub-national levels.

- **Synergy:** The functioning of India's statistical framework relies heavily on the synergy between national bodies like MoSPI and state bodies like the Kerala DES.
- **Evidence-Based Policy:** From setting national monetary policy to guiding Kerala's decentralized panchayat spending, reliable data forms the backbone of governance.
- **Future Directions:** Both departments are rapidly moving towards digital data collection, real-time analytics, and stronger administrative data integration to reduce survey delays.